



## Diet of dung

Watched by its partner, a male African dung beetle creates a ball by rolling the dung of large mammals. The ball is up to 2 in (5 cm) across, and the beetles will bury it to create a food store for their young. Dung beetles have a keen sense of smell and are some of nature's most efficient recyclers. Thanks to their work, dung produced by rhinos and elephants disappears within a few days.



## Bone breaker

After teeth, bones are the hardest parts of dead remains. They may look unappetizing, but they contain bone marrow—a soft and nutritious food. Hyenas crush bones with their super-strong jaws, and then swallow the pieces with the rest of their food, which includes skin and hooves. Inside the hyena's body, powerful stomach acids dissolve the bone, so that it travels through the digestive system without doing any harm. A hyena's stomach acids also kill bacteria, letting it feed on rotting meat without becoming sick.

Hard bone containing soft bone marrow

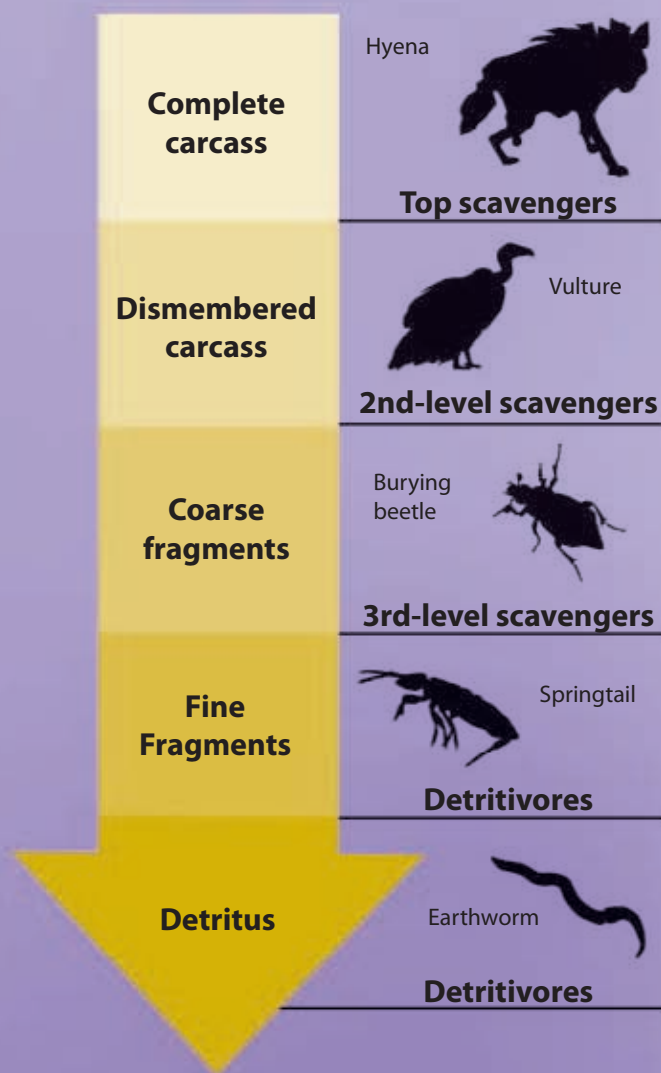


White-backed vulture with short feathers on head and neck



## Submerged scavengers

In water, dead remains eventually sink, so most of the scavengers live on the seabed or in the sediment on muddy shores. This rock is covered by brittle stars, which scavenge food by reaching upward with several arms, while the remaining arms hold them in place. Each arm is covered with sticky mucus, which traps particles of food drifting down. In deeper parts of the ocean, brittle stars often feed on dead fish. They wriggle their way toward it across the seabed, attracted by its scent.



## Breaking down remains

Scavengers work like an assembly line in reverse, breaking down dead remains. Top scavengers, such as hyenas, feed on large pieces of food. At the other end of the scale, detritivores, such as springtails and earthworms, feed on the tiny particles that become mixed up in the soil. This is not the end of the story, because detritivores produce waste as they feed. This waste is processed by microscopic fungi and bacteria, which keep soil fertile, helping plants to grow.